

Choosing a Workplace: Values and Company Culture

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When considering a future workplace, one of the most important factors to consider are the company's internal culture and core values. Corporate culture does not end at a mission statement; it extends into the behaviors of all stakeholders, expectations, and work-life balance that is supported by management. Although salary is also just as important, finding a company that has an interest to protect its employees must also be considered. By comparing two companies— The Sonnenalp Luxury Resort in Vail and Amazon— we see the differences that determine the value of a company, and if they are worth working for in terms of a healthy workplace.

A Values-Based Culture: The Sonnenalp Hotel

The Sonnenalp in Vail, Colorado is a family-owned luxury resort known for its warm hospitality, Bavarian-style service, and inclusive community. Not only does this apply to guests, but it also extends to all their employees. Employees are treated like family, and are given a wide range of benefits including generous discounts on many hotel services, opportunities for growth, employee housing, insurance benefits, and much more (Sonnenalp, n.d.). Working for them, I notice that their support for their employees shows how much they value them as individuals with needs, and not just an extended tool of the hotel. By making their work experience as customizable, personal, and caring as the guests', the Sonnenalp is likely to see high employee retention rates. It also shows demonstrates their care to support their employees in an industry where burnout is common.

Besides great employee benefits, The Sonnenalp continues to resemble a values-based culture where the shared beliefs of diversity, sustainability, and *gemütlichkeit* service are driven by going through with their policies and projects, which is at the heart of their hospitality service

(Sonnenalp, n.d.). The hotel and their history shows the emphasis of keeping “exceptional people” — stakeholders who are responsible for ensuring a responsible work dynamic— involved with their services, and following up with discipline measures if they are not met such as firing. Their focus also reaches their community of Vail and the nearby Eagle River Valley. With ongoing sustainability developments and caring for wildlife, leadership have shown their commitment to preserving the beauty of the landscape and experience for locals (Sonnenalp, n.d.). Their approach to show generosity to those around them demonstrates their care to leave a positive impact and their ethical approach to support various entities makes them an attractive workplace.

A Compliance-Based Culture: Amazon

In contrast, Amazon, while much more recognizable globally, has been criticized for a workplace culture that prioritizes efficiency and growth over employee well-being and compensation. Amazon has faced several challenges including long work hours, aggressive quotas, and lack of communication with their employees (Ferrell and Ferrell 2021). While the Sonnenalp shows caring for their employees with great benefits fit for the tough work that is hospitality, Amazon approaches their employees with a lack of empathy and understanding for their needs. Because of this, Amazon is met with protests, and management firing those who do not wish to work the way they intended as they can be “replaced.” Such strict rules indicate an environment that would not have supported high rates of employee retention or morale.

This exemplifies how they are a compliance-based culture, where rules and procedures are used to control behavior at any cost, the “traditional workplace environment,” rather than inspire an ethical commitment to their line of work. Although Amazon has made strides in sustainability practices such as reducing the amount of packaging material they use, its internal

culture shows an imbalance with their “dehumanizing” labor practices (Amazon 2024). By following this specific ethical approach, it can be puzzling to note why they would put more emphasis on resolving the packaging issue instead of the labor issue which occurred around the same time. The lack of ethical leadership in some areas compared to others is concerning, and is a major reason why Amazon should be avoided as a place for work.

Conclusion

Choosing a company to work for is a deeply personal decision that should not only align with salary but also the ethical commitment of the company itself. The Sonnenalp represents an ideal fit for the type of workplace I wish to work in, while Amazon represent aspects of corporate culture I wish to avoid. Hospitality in this sense seems more relaxed and inviting compared to being expected to follow strict rules and regulations that prevent me from prioritizing my well-being. The type of work one should work in should largely be based on the enjoyment and work-life balance it provides, perhaps away from the typical traditional work environment.

References

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